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Feminist AI: Feminist Perspectives on Artificial Intelligence (AI) in the Workplace

Technofeminism at Work: Artificial Intelligence-Mediated Negotiations and the Reproduction of Gendered Communication Norms

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ABSTRACT

This study examines how artificial intelligence (AI) reshapes gender dynamics in workplace negotiations. Adopting a technofeminist lens, we conceptualize gender–technology relations as mutually shaping and fluid. Using a convergent mixed-methods design, participants negotiated job offers with an AI chatbot recruiter. Qualitative transcript analysis identified gendered communication patterns, which were complemented by quantitative measures of negotiation outcomes and pre- and post-survey results. Findings reveal a paradox: AI-mediated negotiations muted traditional gender gaps—women and men achieved comparable outcomes—yet masculine-coded communication styles were associated with higher scores than feminine-coded communication styles. Participants also anthropomorphized the AI, projecting gendered identities that shaped satisfaction and outcomes. We introduce the concept of *recursive human-AI gender learning* to explain how humans and algorithms iteratively train one another, reproducing gendered communication norms within seemingly neutral systems. The study contributes to feminist AI scholarship by illuminating how AI both disrupts and reproduces gendered power relations in organizational life.

1 | Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) technologies are reshaping workplaces, influencing how organizations recruit, evaluate, and interact with employees. Increasingly, AI systems are not only tools for processing information but also counterparts in communication—for example, conducting initial résumé screenings, interviews, and responding to HR inquiries. This transformation raises important questions about how AI redefines core workplace processes. One such process is negotiation, where outcomes shape not only pay but also opportunities and long-term career trajectories.

Negotiation has long been identified as a key arena where gender inequalities emerge and amplify: Women, on average, negotiate less frequently, face greater social penalties when they do, and achieve lower economic outcomes compared to men (Bowles et al. 2022; Mazei et al. 2015). These differences are often rooted *not* in ability but in the gendered dynamics of communication, stereotype threat, and societal expectations of who is permitted to be agentic or communal in workplace interactions (Amanatullah and Morris 2010; Eagly and Karau 2002).

As AI enters the domain of negotiation, its role as a counterpart or mediator introduces both opportunities and risks (Sarala et al. 2025). Optimists suggest that AI could reduce disparities by serving as a neutral interlocutor, free of the biases and sanction cues that constrain women in human-to-human negotiations. Critics caution, however, that AI systems built on biased data, design choices, and algorithms may replicate or even amplify

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inequalities (Kelan 2025). This paradox underscores the need for examining how AI systems may treat negotiation *not* as a neutral or rational exchange but as a social interaction where gendered power is continually performed and interpreted.

We position this study within the emerging field of feminist AI (Toupin 2024; Wajcman and Young 2023), which combines feminist epistemology and AI scholarship to examine how sociotechnical systems reproduce and reconfigure power relations at work. Building on technofeminist theory (Faulkner 2001; Wajcman 2004), we view AI as a sociotechnical actor whose design and deployment reflect human values and hierarchies. From this perspective, AI-mediated negotiation provides a critical setting for observing how gendered communication patterns are interpreted and rewarded in algorithmic interaction.

Using a convergent mixed-methods design (Fetters et al. 2013), we examine whether AI-mediated negotiation attenuates gender gaps or reinforces gendered communication norms in a job-offer simulation involving 51 participants negotiating with an AI-based HR manager chatbot. Integrating *qualitative* analysis of negotiation transcripts with *quantitative* outcomes and pre- and post-survey data, a paradoxical pattern emerged: Women and men achieved comparable negotiation outcomes, yet traditionally masculine communication styles—characterized by directness, forcefulness, and assertiveness—were more strongly rewarded in this AI-mediated setting. At the same time, participants anthropomorphized the AI, projecting gendered identities that influence their satisfaction and results. These findings suggest that bias in AI-mediated negotiations operates less through differential treatment by gender identity, and more through the privileging of historically gendered standards of competence embedded in AI systems and through user interactions. Although AI may appear neutral, it implicitly rewards a narrow masculine model of effective negotiation, to which humans adapt while also bringing their own assumptions and biases to the interaction.

Building on the findings, we advance the technofeminist theory by proposing the concept of *recursive human–AI gender learning*, through which communicative norms are co-produced as humans and algorithms iteratively shape one another in real time. This perspective extends research on gender and AI beyond algorithmic bias to show how everyday human–AI interactions can reproduce organizational norms associated with the "ideal male worker" (Acker 1990), even in ostensibly gender-neutral systems.

2 | Theoretical Framework and Hypotheses Development

2.1 | Technofeminism and the Co-Construction of Gender and Technology

Feminist scholars have long argued that gender and technology are interdependent rather than independent spheres (Faulkner 2001; Wajcman 1991, 2004). Early critiques showed that modern technologies, such as industrial machinery and office automation, evolved within male-dominated institutions and thus came to embody masculine cultural values (Wajcman 1991). As Wajcman (1991) contends, technology has constituted a masculine culture, entwined with male privilege and power, such that "technical skill" has historically been defined in alignment with traits and fields traditionally dominated by men. In this view, technologies are not neutral tools but sociotechnical products that reflect and reinforce prevailing gender hierarchies (Wajcman 1991, 2004).

At the same time, technofeminism emphasizes the mutual shaping of gender and technology relations, rejecting both technological determinism and gender essentialism (Wajcman 2004). It highlights that technologies can reinforce gender inequality, but they can also be reconfigured through feminist intervention and intentional design. More gender-equitable technologies thus emerge through politics and design practice rather than claims of neutrality, positioning technofeminism between early cyber-optimism (that digital realms might erase embodied gender differences) and pessimistic critiques that saw technology as fundamentally patriarchal (Wajcman 2004).

Empirically, offline power dynamics often reassert themselves online as users carry ingrained habits and biases into digital interaction (Wajcman 2004). This aligns with social-constructionist approaches to gender, which conceptualize gender as an ongoing interpretive accomplishment rather than a fixed attribute (Brickell 2006). Research on fairness in machine learning similarly conceptualizes AI systems as operating within a *data–algorithm–user interaction feedback loop* (Mehrabi et al. 2021). Within this loop, bias may arise through *historical bias* embedded in training data, *algorithmic bias* introduced during model development and optimization, and *emergent bias* as a result of interaction with users in real-world contexts. Because AI systems are built from human-generated data and calibrated through human-defined reward structures and user interaction, socially patterned behaviors and norms may become encoded, stabilized, and amplified in technological infrastructures.

Importantly, these patterned behaviors are not only gendered, they are also embedded within broader intersecting systems of race, class, and geopolitical power relations. Intersectional feminists demonstrate that gendered hierarchies are inseparable from racialized and class structures of inequality (Collins 2000; Crenshaw 1989). What Wajcman (2004) terms the masculine culture of design is also historically aligned with Whiteness, Western rationality, and elite organizational norms. AI systems, as products of these contexts, are thus co-constructed within multiple overlapping hierarchies of power.

Feminist analyses of AI foreground the institutional and organizational conditions under which data-driven systems are designed, governed, and deployed. The "digital gender divide" concerns not only a matter of access but also learning, skills, and participation in shaping technology (Wajcman and Young 2023). Achieving gender equity in AI therefore requires more than increasing women's representation in tech workplaces; it demands transforming the organizational culture and power structures of tech companies, including addressing the masculine defaults and "brogrammer" cultures that contribute to persistent exclusion (Acker 1990; Wajcman and Young 2023; Young et al. 2023).

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In short, technofeminism moves beyond questions of representation to examine the historically White, capitalist, and masculine-coded values embedded in AI systems (Wajcman 2006; Young et al. 2023). These values include traits such as competitiveness, speed, mastery, and individualism, historically aligning expertise with a White male identity. Technofeminism directs us to examine AI as a sociotechnical artifact: How does it disrupt or reproduce existing gender dynamics? How do humans interact with AI to yield new patterns of equality or inequality? We apply this technofeminist lens to examine AI-mediated workplace negotiations.

2.2 | Gender Inequality in Workplace Negotiation

Building on this technofeminist view, negotiation is a well-established context for gender disparity in organizations. Meta-analytic research shows that, in traditional in-person negotiations, women often achieve worse economic outcomes than men (Mazei et al. 2015). These patterns reflect both differential expectations and biased responses to gendered communication styles (Mazei et al. 2015). Negotiation is culturally coded as a masculine domain that valorizes assertiveness, self-promotion, and value claiming (Eagly and Karau 2002; Kray et al. 2001). Because these agentic traits align with norms of effective negotiation performance, individuals who display communal or stereotypically feminine behaviors—such as warmth, modesty, or deference—tend to be viewed as less influential counterparts and secure lower outcomes (Bowles et al. 2022; Kray et al. 2001). An example illustrating the differences is linguistic hedging, which women are more likely to use (e.g., "Maybe," "perhaps," or "I think,") to soften claims and avoid imposing their views on others; although hedging can facilitate rapport and face-saving in interaction, it may also be interpreted as uncertainty or lack of confidence in competitive negotiation contexts (Newman et al. 2008).

Moreover, gendered expectations magnify these effects for women: When women display assertiveness or self-advocacy, they risk social backlash for violating prescriptive norms of femininity (Amanatullah and Morris 2010; Rudman and Glick 2001). This double bind, where feminine behavior is economically penalized, and agentic behavior is socially sanctioned, creates unique constraints on women's negotiation performance. Stereotype threat further heightens self-monitoring and anxiety, which dampens performance (Von Hippel et al. 2011). Importantly, these effects are contextually contingent: Gender gaps shrink in conditions that lower social penalties or recast the role (e.g., negotiating for others) (Mazei et al. 2015).

This raises a key question: can AI-mediated negotiations alter gender outcomes? In traditional in-person negotiations, visible or audible gender cues often activate stereotypes that disadvantage women. When the cues are obscured, gender gaps can narrow. For example, Greenberg and Petrie (2024) found that women earned significantly less than men when gender was apparent (e.g., face-to-face or via identifiable voice/profile), but the gap disappeared when gender cues were obscured (e.g., anonymous text or voice modulation). This pattern aligns with the technofeminist arguments that digital mediation can disrupt routine gendered evaluations (Wajcman 2004). From a social-constructionist perspective, removing visible gender markers reduces the social pressures that typically influence how women "do gender" (Brickell 2006; West and Zimmerman 1987), weakening the link between gender identity and negotiation performance. Accordingly, we expect that introducing an AI chatbot mediator may attenuate the typical gender gap in traditional in-person negotiation outcomes by loosening gendered constraints.

Hypothesis 1. *In AI-mediated text-based negotiations, there will be no significant differences in negotiation outcomes between participants identifying as women and those identifying as men.*

2.3 | Algorithmic Affordances and Gendered Communication

Although AI-mediated negotiations may attenuate gender differentials observed in in-person settings, a critical question remains: Which communication styles do these systems learn to recognize and reward? Technofeminism highlights that digital infrastructures embed gendered values, and often reflect masculine techno-capitalist priorities that privilege speed, productivity, and outcomes over relational or affective dimensions of work (Wajcman 2006; Wajcman and Young 2023). Text-based algorithmic negotiation favors concise task-oriented exchanges, creating conditions in which direct and assertive language becomes especially effective (Guiller and Durndell 2007). Consistent with negotiation research showing that agentic strategies yield higher distributive gains (Kray et al. 2001; Mazei et al. 2015), large language models (LLMs) trained on historical data where agentic phrasing correlates with negotiation success may internalize and reproduce these masculine-coded advantages through their design choices and optimization processes.

Additionally, bias in AI systems may arise not only from historical bias in training data and algorithmic bias in model design and optimization but also during model evaluation and deployment. Mehrabi et al. (2021) identify *evaluation bias*, which can occur when human annotators or raters score model output during assessment processes. To the extent that raters apply socially patterned standards in judging what counts as appropriate, persuasive, or professional, those criteria become embedded in AI system behavior (Kelan 2025; Mehrabi et al. 2021). Because agentic communications align with the idealized model of the "ideal worker" (Acker 1990), such styles may be disproportionately rewarded by raters during evaluation and subsequently reinforced through model optimization procedures.

Bias may also emerge during deployment, as real-world interaction with human users generates feedback effects (Ferrando 2014; Glickman and Sharot 2025; Mehrabi et al. 2021). As individuals negotiate with AI counterparts, they may learn, often implicitly, which linguistic patterns elicit favorable responses, such as higher offers or faster concessions, and adjust their communication accordingly. In this interactive process, gender and

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technology are co-constituted (Faulkner 2001; Wajcman 2004): The system reflects historically and socially patterned norms while simultaneously shaping what users recognize as effective negotiation behavior through what it recognizes and rewards. Rather than a neutral exchange, this iterative process illustrates a form of algorithmic performativity, through which humans and machines mutually reinforce and stabilize gendered communicative norms. Thus, AI systems not only learn from humans but also shape human behavior, reinforcing gendered expectations within an ongoing data–algorithm–user interaction feedback loop (Mehrabi et al. 2021).

Therefore, even as AI-mediated negotiation may appear to level outcomes (Hypothesis 1), it may conceal a deeper underlying continuity of gendered values. We expect that the criteria for "successful" negotiation in AI remain aligned with masculine-coded traits—assertiveness, control, mastery, and individualism—over relational or communal approaches more often associated with femininity. AI may legitimize and amplify the communicative styles it privileges, reinforcing cultural linkages between agentic behaviors and competence. This underscores technofeminism's critique of technological neutrality: Digital systems may equalize opportunity while still privileging one gendered way of being over another. Furthermore, through an intersectional technofeminist lens (Wajcman and Young 2023), the AI's reinforcement of agentic communication may amplify existing hierarchies not only of gender but also of race, class, ethnicity, sexuality, and culture, privileging communication styles historically associated with dominant groups and reinforcing overlapping hierarchies of power. Therefore, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2. *In AI-mediated text-based negotiations, masculine-coded language will be associated with higher negotiated outcomes than feminine-coded language.*

In summary, this study builds on Wajcman (1991, 2004, 2006) technofeminist perspective to examine how gender and technology are co-constructed in emerging workplace interactions. We advance two complementary hypotheses that capture this tension. Hypothesis 1 proposes that AI-mediated negotiation can disrupt gender inequality by reducing interpersonal bias and stereotype threat. Hypothesis 2, in contrast, proposes that AI-mediated negotiation may reproduce inequality by privileging masculine-coded norms. Figure 1 presents our conceptual model integrating these hypotheses, illustrating how AI mediation may function as both a disrupter and reinforcer of gendered power dynamics in negotiations.

3 | Research Design and Methods

3.1 | Research Design of AI Salary Negotiation

We employed a convergent mixed-methods design (Fetters et al. 2013) to link *how* participants negotiate with *what* they achieve. This approach is well suited to our research aims: quantitative data capture measurable negotiation performance, whereas qualitative transcript data identify the communication patterns used to reach those outcomes. By integrating these complementary sources, our methodological choices strengthen inferential robustness and enhance the study's potential impact.

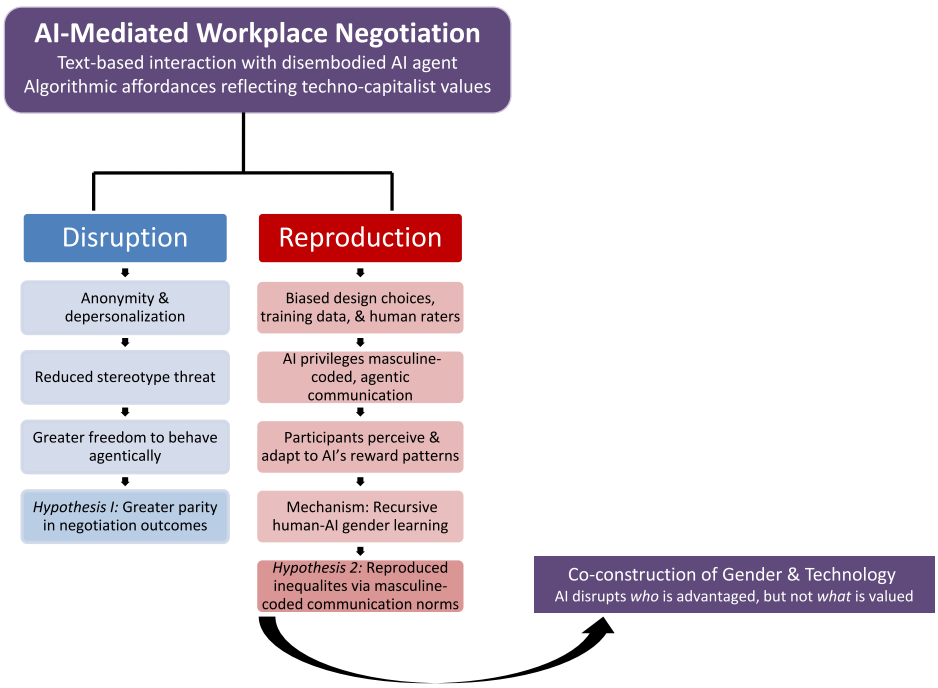


FIGURE 1 | Technofeminist model of AI-mediated negotiations. The model summarizes how AI-mediated negotiations function as a sociotechnical site where gender and technology are co-constructed. The AI's disembodied design reduces interpersonal bias (disruption) while its algorithmic affordances privilege masculine-coded communication (reproduction). Through recursive human–AI gender learning, these interactions can simultaneously attenuate and reinforce gendered power relations. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

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The study used a simulated job-offer negotiation between human participants and an AI counterpart. Salary negotiation is a consequential context because initial offers often set long-term earning trajectories, with small differences compounding over time (Babcock and Laschever 2021; Maitra et al. 2021). This setting therefore provides both theoretical relevance and practical significance for examining AI-mediated negotiation processes and outcomes.

The research protocol consisted of three stages: (1) A pre-negotiation survey administered via Qualtrics; (2) a negotiation simulation with an AI chatbot; and (3) a post-negotiation survey administered via Qualtrics. A unique identifier was generated in the pre-survey and was used across all stages to link datasets. The qualitative component consisted of negotiation transcripts between the participants and the AI–HR manager chatbot, capturing theoretically relevant gendered communication patterns. The quantitative component included pre- and post-survey measures and negotiation outcomes produced by the simulation (e.g., individual scores and joint gains). Data integration occurred at the individual participant level by aligning qualitative codes with corresponding quantitative measures, enabling fully integrated mixed-methods analysis (Fetters et al. 2013).

3.2 | AI-Negotiation Simulation

The AI-mediated negotiation was implemented through the *New Recruit* simulation (Neale 2018) on the iDecisionGames (iDG) platform, commonly used in higher education to teach negotiation concepts (e.g., distributive vs. integrative bargaining). Negotiation interaction occurred entirely via text, with each participant acting as a job candidate, individually negotiating employment terms with an AI-driven HR manager chatbot. Both sides negotiated eight issues within 1 h (e.g., salary, start date, location, vacation time, and bonus). Each issue carried point values reflecting differing priorities of the job candidate and the AI–HR manager. The negotiation included distributive issues (e.g., salary), where the candidate's gains entailed the AI-HR manager's loss, and integrative issues (e.g., location), where mutually beneficial trade-offs were possible. Points were summed to produce each participant's negotiation outcome; higher totals indicated better performance, with a maximum possible score of 13,200.

In this study, AI refers to generative artificial intelligence, systems that generate human-like text through probabilistic pattern recognition. The negotiation simulation was based on OpenAI's ChatGPT-4.1, a widely used general-purpose LLM trained on large-scale internet text. The chatbot acted as the negotiating counterpart by interpreting offers, formulating counteroffers, and performing social functions, such as acknowledging preferences and maintaining rapport in real time. The model was prompted to "stay professional, human-like, and fair, but advocate for the company's interests" and was provided only the employer's point structure, creating information asymmetry typical of real-world job offer negotiation. The AI appeared neutrally as "HR Manager," without gendered cues such as name or avatar.

We highlight that language patterns in AI constitute a critical dimension for future research given the sociotechnical opacity of these systems (Budhwar et al. 2023). Although designed to emulate natural language, training data, model architecture, and alignment procedures remain largely proprietary (Rai 2020); such opacity is not purely technical but conceals value-laden decisions about which linguistic patterns and communicative norms are encoded as appropriate or effective. Alignment procedures, such as reinforcement learning from human feedback, in which human raters evaluate model output for appropriateness, embed prevailing social norms and organizational priorities into the system's communication patterns.

3.3 | Data Collection

As job offer negotiation is often the first significant professional negotiation for college students, participants were undergraduate students ($N = 51$) at a public U.S. college (M age = 21). All data were collected anonymously. The sample was diverse in academic backgrounds (e.g., business, psychology, and other majors) and reflected early-career work experience, with 79% reporting 1–6 years of part-time or full-time employment. Sixty-nine percent identified as women ($n = 35$), 29% as men ($n = 15$), and 2% as non-binary ($n = 1$).

Following the research design process, participants first completed a brief pre-survey on the extent of prior negotiation training and experience and AI familiarity. Participants then received a two-page scenario briefing describing the issues to be negotiated. After concluding the negotiation, participants completed a post-negotiation survey to report their perceptions of the AI-mediated negotiations and provide demographic information. The full session of pre-survey, negotiation, and post-survey took place in a computer lab and took approximately 30–60 min per participant. Participation was entirely voluntary, with extra credit provided as an incentive. Ethical approval for this study was obtained from the Institutional Review Board (Reference ID 294). All participants provided informed consent prior to data collection.

3.4 | Data Analysis

To test our theoretical framework and hypotheses, we merged qualitative and quantitative data for analysis (Fetters et al. 2013). This integration allows us to both observe the lived negotiation dynamics and quantify their economic and perceptual impacts—a complementarity emphasized by mixed-methods scholars and essential for advancing theory in emerging interdisciplinary fields such as human–AI interaction (Wickert et al. 2021).

First, we conducted a deductive quantitative content analysis (Miles et al. 2014) of negotiation transcripts, focusing on the communication patterns. This approach begins with a theoretically derived coding framework that defines a priori categories, enabling comparison across cases (Miles et al. 2014). Drawing from Bem (1974) gender schema theory (masculine and feminine traits), studies on gendered language in digital contexts

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(Guiller and Durndell 2007; Hussey et al. 2015), and negotiation research on gender differences (Kray and Thompson 2004), we defined four overarching communication style categories to guide our coding: feminine, masculine, androgynous, and undifferentiated. Masculine style was coded when a participant's language emphasized agency, assertiveness, task orientation, and control; and feminine style was coded when a participant expressed communality, interpersonal sensitivity, emotional warmth, and relational support. Androgynous style integrated salient relatively balanced expressions of both agency and communality within the conversational exchange. Undifferentiated style was low in both agency and communality, often vague, disengaged, emotionally flat, or lacking a clear strategic orientation.

Based on this guiding framework, we developed a coding manual consisting of coding rules (see Appendix A for the full scheme). Examples of coding rules included: Use of hedging phrases or apologetic language as a marker of "Feminine" style (e.g., "maybe we could consider ..." or "sorry, but ..."); use of imperatives or numeric arguments as "Masculine" style (e.g., "I need at least $60K" or "We only have 15 min left"); presence of both collaborative and assertive elements as "Androgynous" (e.g., "Let's find a solution that works for both of us"—cooperative intent combined with goal orientation); and very brief generic responses as "Undifferentiated" (e.g., one-word replies like "OK" that convey no relational or assertive tone).

We did not adopt a fully discursive or conversation–analytic approach because our aim was not to conduct micro-linguistic analysis of turn-taking and interactional sequencing (Potter 2003); rather, we analyzed complete negotiation transcripts to identify theory-driven communication styles that could be meaningfully linked to negotiation outcomes and participants' perceptions. As our analysis below shows, individuals of all genders drew on a range of gendered communication styles when negotiating with the AI–HR manager, with no fixed or uniform pattern by gender. Table 1 summarizes the study's coding categories with indicative gendered language markers for job candidates and the AI–HR manager.

We then utilized an AI-assisted human-in-the-loop coding approach: Each researcher independently used ChatGPT-4.1 (GPT) as an analytic aid to code the human-AI chat transcripts at the conversation-level, identifying dominant language patterns for both human participants and the AI–HR manager chatbot. GPT models have been recognized for their capacity to recognize and classify linguistic patterns effectively, whereas human oversight ensures the reliability and validity of qualitative coding (Chattopadhyay et al. 2025). Each researcher generated provisional code for participants and their corresponding AI counterpart, supported by exemplar quotes and GPT-generated justifications. Coding results were then compared to assess reliability. Discrepancies (approximately 10%) or ambiguous cases were resolved through team discussion, revisiting the transcript and the original quotes, and applying the coding manual.

Each participant and AI counterpart was ultimately assigned a predominant communication style at the conversation level. Consistent with feminist research traditions, we acknowledge the interpretive nature and the partiality of this analysis. Adopting a relational epistemology, we recognize that our interpretations are co-constructed with the data and shaped by our scholarly standpoint within technofeminist and organizational frameworks.

Once language-pattern categories for each participant and the corresponding AI–HR manager were finalized, these labels were merged into the individual-level dataset using participants' unique identifiers, creating a single analytic file for statistical analysis. To test Hypothesis 1, we examined these quantitative measures to compare men's versus women's performance. We performed independent-samples *t*-tests (or non-parametric equivalents when normality assumptions were not met) comparing women's and men's performance outcomes. We also examined the association between communication style and outcomes. Throughout, a significance threshold of $p < 0.05$ was used, with $p < 0.10$ noted as marginal significance. To test Hypothesis 2, we then analyzed the quantitative negotiation outcomes based on gendered language patterns. In addition, we conducted exploratory analyses comparing the distribution of language style categories across women and men using a Chi-squared test of independence. We also examined the AI's language style across all sessions and tabulated participants' responses to the perceived AI–HR manager gender question. Finally, we examined how participants' gender may have influenced perception of the AI's gender.

4 | Findings

4.1 | Gender Differences of AI-Negotiation Outcome

We first examined gender differences in AI-mediated negotiation outcomes. Across economic indicators, women and men achieved statistically comparable results. Although men obtained slightly higher mean scores than women, the difference was not statistically significant, $t(28.41) = -0.97$, $p = 0.34$ (men: $M = 9713$, SD = 3651 and women: $M = 8597$, SD = 3876). Similarly, salary outcomes showed no significant gender difference, $t(30.95) = -0.93$, $p = 0.36$ (men: $M = \$117{,}000$, SD = 5606 and women: $M = 115{,}294$, SD = 6507). Integrative outcomes were measured by the dyadic scores reflecting joint gains from trade-offs, such as obtaining a higher bonus in exchange for conceding vacation time. No significant gender difference was observed, $t(46) = 0.48$, $p = 0.63$ (men: $M = 6240$, SD = 2451 and women: $M = 6564$, SD = 2001). In sum, the findings support Hypothesis 1, indicating parity between women and men in economic outcomes during AI-mediated negotiations. Table 2 summarizes these comparisons.

This result contrasts with much of the traditional negotiation literature where male negotiators often have an advantage (Mazei et al. 2015) and is more consistent with studies of virtual negotiations that found reduced gender gaps (Stuhlmacher et al. 2007). It suggests that the AI-mediated context may have attenuated gender-based disparities. The null difference persisted after controlling for covariates such as prior negotiation experience and

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TABLE 1 | Examples of coding categories and indicative language markers for job candidate and AI–HR manager.

Dyad IDs	Job candidate gendered language markers	Candidate justification	AI-HR manager gendered language markers	HR manager justification
3	Androgynous	The candidate begins with **clear, firm numeric expectations** (e.g., "120,000–135,000") and **direct refusals** (e.g., "no," "I would like 120,000 or more"), suggesting **masculine assertiveness**. However, the tone shifts to **softer, relational phrasing** later (e.g., "I would like to be somewhere around California," "that would be wonderful"), showing flexibility and relational tone—**Hallmarks of androgynous style**. Overall, the candidate expresses priorities while remaining open to alternatives, signaling **cooperative intent**	Androgynous	The HR manager uses **structured, task-based language** (masculine-coded) while also showing empathy and flexibility (e.g., "I understand your position," "That's understandable," "Great to hear that"), balancing task control with responsiveness. The repeated strategy of asking for preferences and offering workable compromises fits a **collaborative orientation** that promotes joint value creation and rapport building
15	Masculine	The candidate engages in **extensive numeric anchoring and counteroffers** (e.g., "2.8% with 103,000," "Can we do 2.8% with 105,000?"), shows **persistent rejections** of proposed offers, and continually reopens negotiations even after temporary agreement. They focus on **leverage, precision, and transactional outcomes**, typical of **masculine-coded language and framing**. Although the final outcome is a compromise, it results from **repeated distributive tactics**, not cooperative framing	Androgynous	The HR manager demonstrates **persistence and emotional restraint**, maintains **structured progress** (e.g., cycling through negotiation categories), and repeatedly **acknowledges the candidate's requests** without escalating tension. They respond with **rational concessions** and explore trade-offs (e.g., salary vs. bonus), illustrating **collaborative orientation** and **androgynous communication style**
17	Undifferentiated	The candidate responds in a **succinct, direct, and factual manner**, providing preferences without elaboration or emotional framing (e.g., "Division A," "16 days," "Plan A"). This lack of affective or stylistic cues suggests **an undifferentiated communication style**. However, the tone is respectful, and the candidate accepts terms without pushback, demonstrating a **collaborative orientation** throughout	Androgynous	The HR manager provides a **structured yet affirming tone**, walking through each topic in a logical sequence while maintaining **positive framing** ("Thank you for letting me know ..."). This combination of **task structure and interpersonal responsiveness** reflects an **androgynous and collaborative negotiation style**
19	Feminine	The candidate openly shares **personal context** (e.g., caring for newborn, being a single mother), frames negotiation points around **family needs**, and uses **emotionally expressive language** to explain their positions (e.g., "to	Androgynous	The HR manager exhibits a **task-structured yet highly empathetic approach**, accommodating changes (e.g., adjusting start date for childcare, honoring location due to family), and offering clear trade-

(Continues)

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TABLE 1 | (Continued)

Dyad IDs	Job candidate gendered language markers	Candidate justification	AI-HR manager gendered language markers	HR manager justification
		provide for my daughter"). This framing aligns strongly with a **feminine communication style**. While they hold firm on some key items (e.g., refusing reduced bonus), their tone remains **respectful and relational**, indicating a **collaborative orientation** overall		offs. They use **relational framing** (e.g., "I understand your situation") paired with structured offers, showing an **androgynous and collaborative negotiation style**

TABLE 2 | Comparison of negotiation outcomes by participant (candidate) gender.

Variable	Women *M* (SD)	Men *M* (SD)	*t*	df	*p*
Salary (USD)	115,294 (6507)	117,000 (5606)	−0.93	30.95	0.36
Candidate score	8597 (3876)	9713 (3651)	−0.97	28.41	0.34
Team (dyad) score	6564 (2001)	6240 (2451)	0.48	46.00	0.63

Note: All monetary values are in U.S. dollars ($USD). Independent-samples *t*-tests were used to compare means between men and women. All *p*-values are two-tailed. Abbreviations: *M*, mean; SD, standard deviation.

business major; neither of those factors revealed hidden gender gaps.

4.2 | Gendered Language Patterns and Negotiation Outcome

Whereas gender itself did not predict economic outcomes, communication style did. Participants using a predominantly masculine-coded communication style achieved higher candidate scores (M = 10,079, SD = 3908) than those using a feminine style (M = 7523, SD = 3319), $t(24.82) = -1.84$, $p = 0.04$ (one-tailed). Notably, masculine-coded language was the most common among participants attaining the maximum possible candidate score (13,200). Table 3 summarizes these comparisons.

To further explore how linguistic style is related to negotiation performance, we divided candidate scores into quintiles. As shown in Figure 2, masculine-coded language (coded as 2) was the most prevalent in the top two quintiles, which represented the highest-performing negotiations. Feminine-coded language (coded as 1), by contrast, was disproportionately represented in the bottom three quintiles, corresponding to weaker performance. Androgynous (coded as 3) and undifferentiated (coded as 4) language styles were distributed more evenly across performance levels. Together, these patterns indicate that even within an ostensibly neutral AI-mediated environment, masculine-coded communicative styles were more likely to be rewarded with greater negotiation results, consistent with Hypothesis 2.

In addition, we explored whether women and men use different language patterns when negotiating via an AI chatbot. Although our coding of the negotiation transcripts revealed some differences, they did not reach conventional levels of statistical significance. As shown in Figure 3, women were more often coded as using feminine (29%) or masculine (31%) communication styles, with fewer displaying an androgynous style (17%). In contrast, men were most frequently coded as employing an androgynous (47%) style—blending agentic and communal language—followed by masculine (27%) and feminine (20%) styles. Only 7% of men were undifferentiated, compared with 23% of women.

Whereas women appeared somewhat more polarized in their communication (leaning predominantly communal or predominantly agentic) and men more often balanced, the difference was not statistically significant (χ^2 test, $p = 0.14$). In other words, there were no sharp gender divides in linguistic behavior; women and men demonstrated a range of communication styles. Many women employed assertive agentic language, whereas a sizable minority of men used more communal tone or mixed approaches. This suggests that in an AI-mediated environment, individuals might feel freer to communicate in a way that suits their personal negotiation approach, without as much pressure to conform to gender norms.

Some participants explicitly reflected on whether and potentially how their negotiation behavior differed because they were interacting with an AI chatbot rather than a human manager. In the post-survey, participants were asked, "Did you change your negotiation behavior because your partner was an AI chatbot?" A minority of respondents indicated "No, not at all" (22%), whereas 78% of respondents indicated some degree of change ("Yes, somewhat," 61%; "Yes, significantly," 17%). Those who reported change were prompted to explain how their behavior differed. Several women described adopting a more direct and aggressive style than they would

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TABLE 3 | Comparison of negotiation outcomes by participant (candidate) communication style.

Variable	Feminine (n = 14)	Masculine (n = 15)	Androgynous (n = 13)	Undifferentiated (n = 9)
Salary (USD)	114,643	117,143	116,154	115,556
Candidate score	7523*	10,079*	9508	8389
Team (dyad) score	6686	6343	6550	6133

Note: All monetary values are in U.S. dollars ($USD). Asterisks indicate significant mean differences between feminine and masculine groups, $p = 0.04$.
Abbreviation: *M*, mean.

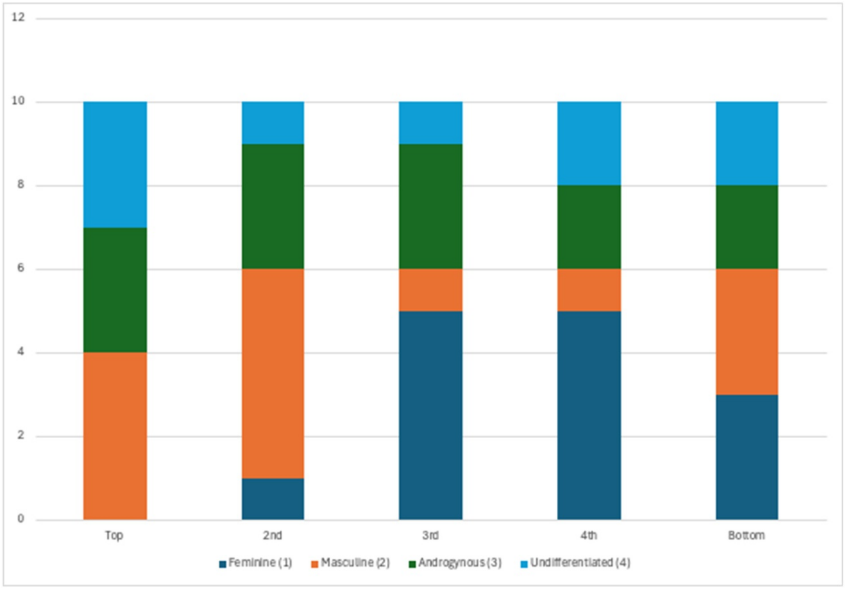


FIGURE 2 | Distribution of communication styles across quintiles of candidate scores. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

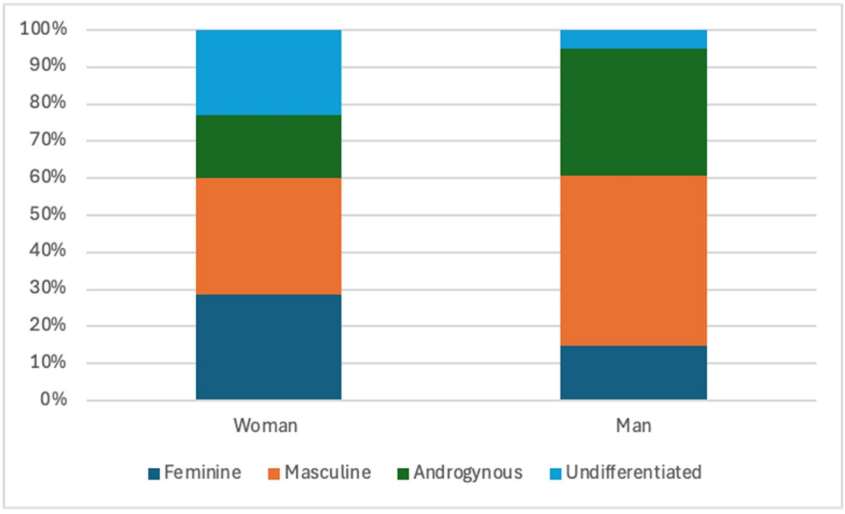


FIGURE 3 | Comparison of gendered communication style by participant gender. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

have otherwise used with a human counterpart. As one participant noted, "I was extremely direct with no reasoning behind my needs and I excluded all emotion." Another participant stated, "I was much more aggressive," whereas another similarly shared, "I was not paying attention to grammar, I was more aggressive." These accounts suggest that participants actively adjusted their communicative strategies in response to the AI-mediated negotiation context.

In short, we did not find definitive evidence of gender differences in language patterns. Communication styles varied widely among both women and men participants, and the overall

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association between participant gender and coded language style was not statistically significant in this sample. These findings suggest that the AI-mediated context muted stereotypical gendered communication patterns, allowing other factors (e.g., values, skill, and personality) to play a more prominent role in shaping negotiation outcomes.

4.3 | AI's Communication Style and Participants' Perceptions

Furthermore, we examined whether the AI negotiation partner communicated in a gendered manner and how participants perceived the AI's gender. Based on our coding of the AI's dialog in all 51 negotiations (each participant–AI pair constituted a dyad), the AI was coded as predominantly gender-neutral: In 92% of cases, its predominant style was coded as androgynous, blending both masculine and feminine traits. The AI combined empathy and firmness, for example:

> I understand the importance of work-life balance. How about we compromise on 16 days of vacation time to strike a balance between your preference and our operational needs? Would that be acceptable to you?
>
> (AI, Dyad 16)

The AI also expressed appreciation while steering the conversation forward, for example, "I appreciate your preference. Moving on to job assignments, which division are you most interested in ..." (AI, Dyad 23). In four cases (8%), the AI was coded as more distinctly feminine (4%) or masculine (4%), with no systematic relation to the human partner's communication style.

However, despite this neutral design, many participants anthropomorphized the chatbot and attributed a gender to it. When asked in the post-survey, participants most often said they viewed the AI as being gender-neutral. Among those who did assign a gender, clear patterns emerged by participant gender: Female participants were significantly more likely to perceive the AI as "female," whereas male participants more often thought it was "male." This association was statistically significant ($\chi^2(2) = 9.21$, $p = 0.01$), suggesting that participants frequently projected their own gender identity onto the AI (see Figure 4).

As shown in Figure 4, 37% of women in our sample perceived the AI as female, compared to only 7% of men. Conversely, 47% of men assumed the AI was male, compared to 23% of women. The remainder (approximately 40% of both women and men) perceived the AI as gender-neutral or other. These patterns highlight the role of user cognition and bias: even in the absence of explicit cues, participants projected gender onto AI. Here, participants often used themselves as a reference, suggesting a subconscious "the AI is similar to me" assumption.

We also explored whether perceiving the AI as male or female related to any differences in participants' experiences. Interestingly, participants who perceived the AI as male reported slightly higher satisfaction and comfort than those who perceived the AI as female or neutral.

Satisfaction ratings (1 = very dissatisfied to 5 = very satisfied) were significantly higher among those who perceived the AI as male ($M = 4.53$, SD = 0.83) than among those who perceived the AI as female ($M = 3.86$, SD = 0.86), $t(27) = 2.14$, and $p = 0.04$. Comfort ratings showed a similar, marginally significant pattern, with higher comfort among those perceiving the AI as male ($M = 4.47$, SD = 0.74) than female ($M = 3.79$, SD = 1.19), $t(21.56) = 1.84$, and $p = 0.08$.

Why might this be the case? A plausible interpretation is that gendered expectations influenced satisfaction. When participants pictured the AI as a male manager, societal biases that accord men higher status may have boosted their trust in its competence. Alternatively, those who perceived the AI as male achieved better outcomes and thus were more satisfied. To test whether perceiving the AI as male was associated with more favorable negotiation outcomes, we conducted independent-samples *t*-tests comparing participants who perceived the AI as male ($n = 20$)

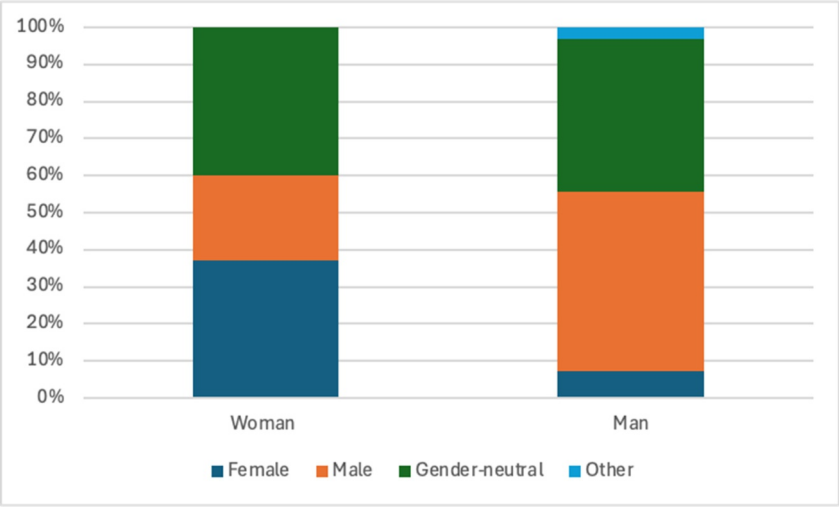


FIGURE 4 | Comparison of perceived AI-HR manager's gender by participant gender. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

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versus female, neutral, or other ($n = 30$). We found that participants who perceived the AI as male obtained significantly higher salaries (M = \$118,000, SD = 3770) with a mean difference of \$3500 than those who did not (M = \$114,500, SD = 7114), $t(46.09) = -2.26$, and $p = 0.03$. They also achieved marginally higher overall candidate scores (M = 10,120, SD = 3190 vs. $M = 8207$, SD = 3986), $t(46.29) = -1.88$, and $p = 0.08$.

We further analyzed whether participants' own gender shaped subjective evaluations of the AI-mediated negotiation. Men reported significantly greater satisfaction with the negotiation outcome ($M = 4.60$, SD = 0.51) than women ($M = 4.20$, SD = 1.02), $t(46.81) = -1.84$, and $p = 0.04$. However, comfort levels did not differ significantly between men ($M = 4.27$, SD = 0.96) and women ($M = 4.23$, SD = 1.06), $t(48) = -0.12$, and $p = 0.45$. These findings suggest that while men reported slightly higher satisfaction with the outcomes of the AI negotiation, gender differences in comfort were negligible.

In summary, in the AI-mediated negotiation, women and men achieved comparable negotiation outcomes, and the AI agent interacted in a largely gender-neutral manner through an androgynous language style. However, participants who employed a masculine language style captured greater value. Furthermore, participants' projections and biases (such as attributing gender to the AI) also shaped subjective experience (e.g., satisfaction). These findings suggest that even in an ostensibly neutral algorithmic environment, gender remains performative and relational: enacted through linguistic style, reproduced through algorithmic pattern recognition, and co-constructed through human interpretation.

5 | Discussion

As organizations increasingly deploy AI for core human resource management tasks, ranging from hiring, promotion, performance review, and decision support, the technology is no longer a peripheral tool but a constitutive element of work (Franklin and Alim 2025; Jones 2025). With scale, speed, and opacity, AI can stabilize or disrupt gendered expectations in subtle ways, privileging some tactics and identities over others. Against this backdrop, our findings offer several critical theoretical and practical implications.

5.1 | AI-Mediated Negotiation and Gender Parity: A Technofeminist Perspective

Our findings suggest that AI systems deployed in HR contexts act not merely as tools but as organizational actors that reshape communication and evaluation processes. Unlike face-to-face negotiations, where men typically secure more favorable terms, no significant gender differences emerged in AI-mediated outcomes, indicating that AI mediation may attenuate gender biases common in traditional negotiations. Consistent with technofeminist theory (Wajcman 2004), technologies embody social values even as they transform them. In this study, the AI agent's disembodied design—lacking gendered cues such as voice, appearance, or name—may have reduced stereotype threat and normative gender expectations.

This result resonates with broader research showing that gender differences in negotiation performance are not immutable traits but contingent on context and expectations (Mazei et al. 2015). When biased social cues and power imbalances are minimized, women perform just as well as men (Stuhlmacher et al. 2007). In our study, because the AI agent may not have perceived participants' gender nor relied on stereotypical gendered schemas, it may have been less susceptible to the subtle often implicit discrimination that can shape human interactions. This suggests that algorithmic systems can disrupt certain patterns of bias that have historically disadvantaged women (Kelan 2025). By reducing human biases and stereotype-driven expectations, the AI context enabled women to negotiate without the usual social penalties or diminished expectations that can constrain their outcomes in face-to-face settings.

5.2 | Masculine-Coded Communication and Algorithmic Norms

Despite comparable outcomes across genders, our analysis indicates that success was associated with a highly agentic, assertive communication style, a pattern widely recognized as masculine-coded in organizational psychology (Eagly and Karau 2002; Kray et al. 2001). Historically, agentic attributes such as dominance, competitiveness, and self-promotion have been culturally associated with masculine roles, whereas communal qualities such as warmth, modesty, and cooperation have been associated with feminine roles (Bem 1974).

From a feminist perspective, this pattern is a double-edged sword. On the one hand, women who employed assertive strategies were not punished in outcome terms—a departure from face-to-face negotiations, where assertive women often face social backlash (Amanatullah and Morris 2010). In our AI-mediated setting, such interpersonal backlash did not emerge. Because the chatbot was not provided participants' gender and did not operate through explicit gendered schemas, the interaction itself lacked gendered social evaluation, potentially enabling women to express agency without fear of social sanction. In this way, AI mediation may create a psychologically safer space for assertive self-advocacy by decoupling agentic negotiation behavior from the gendered penalties that typically accompany it.

On the other hand, the AI's privileging of a masculine-coded style raises critical concerns. Effective negotiation remained aligned with competitive individualism, a script long valorized in patriarchal work cultures (Wajcman 2006). From a feminist perspective, equality achieved by requiring women to perform masculinity merely reconfigures, rather than dismantle, gender hierarchy (Kelan 2025). Here, AI equalized outcomes by assimilating women (and other gender identities) into a hegemonic masculine mode of interaction in real time, echoing feminist critiques that technologies often reproduce dominant values unless intentionally countered (Faulkner 2001; Wajcman 2004).

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In addition, a contribution of our study lies in how participants engaged with the AI itself. Participants routinely anthropomorphized the agents and inferred a gendered persona, often influenced by their own gender identity, even when all gender cues were removed. This suggests that "AI gender" may not necessarily be an inherent system attribute but a perception emergent from user interaction. Building on this insight, we advance the technofeminist theory by showing that gendered communication is recursively co-produced through human–AI interaction rather than a one-way transmission of bias from data to users. Negotiation exchanges created a feedback loop in which humans and AI mutually shaped one another (Glickman and Sharot 2025). As participants adapted their language to elicit favorable responses, they learned what the AI recognized as competent, whereas the AI simultaneously reinforced these agentic scripts. We theorize this process as recursive human–AI gender learning: A dynamic in which human and algorithmic actors iteratively shape gendered communicative norms in real time.

Our findings further demonstrate how an AI system optimized for negotiation efficiency encoded a hierarchy of communication—agentic over communal, forceful over accommodating. Thus, even when outcomes appear gender-neutral, underlying norms remain gendered: The technology privileges assertiveness and control, whereas devaluing cooperation and empathy (i.e., relational work). A feminist AI analysis therefore looks beyond who wins or loses to examine *how* they win and *on whose terms* it is defined. This matters because AI-mediated interaction can function as a normative standard-setter, making masculinized repertoires of competence appear neutral, objective, and appropriate.

Taken together, these findings suggest that AI-mediated negotiations do more than redistribute outcomes; they actively shape what counts as legitimate competence at work. Whereas prior milestones in AI development emphasized machines learning from humans, such as through reinforcement learning in competitive games such as Go, poker, and backgammon (Witt 2025), our study foregrounds an under-theorized inverse dynamic: Humans learning from AI through repeated interaction with algorithmic reward structures. In this case, the negotiation agent implicitly trained participants toward a narrow agentic communication style that the system recognized and rewarded. By theorizing recursive human–AI gender learning, we shift feminist AI analysis from static accounts of bias to a dynamic process model in which gendered norms are co-produced and legitimized through everyday human–AI interaction. Over time and at scale, such processes risk normalizing masculine-coded assertiveness as the default standard of professional competence, even within ostensibly gender-neutral systems.

This theoretical shift is consequential because organizations are rapidly embedding AI into core processes, often without scrutinizing the normative assumptions these systems reinforce (Budhwar et al. 2023; Rai 2020). If AI-mediated interactions systematically privilege certain ways of speaking and value claiming, they may amplify existing organizational cultures while further devaluing relational and care-oriented forms of competence essential for human flourishing (LeBaron et al. 2025). A feminist AI perspective thus reframes algorithmic fairness: Equality concerns not only who benefits in the short term but also which communicative norms and visions of work are amplified (or diminished) over time. Without intentional design interventions, AI risks quietly re-inscribing gendered hierarchies (Acker 1990) by training a new generation of workers to perform competence on masculinized terms, even as surface-level outcome disparities recede.

5.3 | Implications for Feminist AI Design and Governance

Our study contributes to feminist AI scholarship by highlighting a design paradox that designers, organizational leaders, and policymakers must confront: Systems may appear fair in outcomes while institutionalizing narrow standards of competence. Early design and optimization choices, such as what counts as a "good" negotiation outcome and which behaviors are rewarded, may calcify normative values that reflect the biases of the technology's creators or training data (Noble 2018). Without deliberate intervention, AI systems can end up perpetuating dominant ideologies under the guise of neutrality. The practical significance is that AI systems can operate as normative infrastructure: They not only evaluate performance (e.g., through scoring) but also train and standardize communicative expectations at scale.

These findings underscore the importance of adopting feminist design principles from the outset, actively questioning which social norms are embedded in their systems. This could mean incorporating diverse negotiation styles—including both agentic and communal—into training data and success criteria so that algorithms and raters recognize multiple forms of effective communication rather than through a single dominant script. As Wajcman and Young (2023) argue, algorithmic bias reflects a technoculture that privileges masculine norms of expertise; designing for equity thus means rethinking whose knowledge and values guide system development. In practical terms, this means auditing models for not only outcome parity but also how they disproportionately reward a narrow masculine-coded repertoire of communication.

For HR professionals and workplace decision-makers, the challenge is not to treat AI as neutral tools but to recognize them as sites where organizational values and power relations are encoded. Rather than only asking whether AI-mediated tools "close" gender gaps, attention should focus on the assumptions and interactions through which outcomes are produced. Feminist technology studies emphasize that design neutrality is itself political: An algorithm privileges certain communicative repertoires while marginalizing others. A feminist AI governance approach must therefore be intersectional, recognizing that algorithmic norms operate not only along gender lines but through intersecting hierarchies of race, class, and culture that shape whose communication styles and knowledge are recognized as "competent" by AI systems (Collins 2000; Crenshaw 1989).

These concerns are especially relevant in educational and training contexts where AI- powered negotiation simulations

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are already used to teach workplace skills (e.g., platforms such as iDecisionGames built on ChatGPT). Because AI feedback is often less noisy than human feedback, its repeated and seemingly gender-neutral reward signals can make the system's preferences feel authoritative. As Glickman and Sharot (2025) note, even small biases can compound through iterative interaction, producing a "snowball effect" that encourages learners toward wrong behaviors over time. Accordingly, the most immediate implication is precaution: Educators, trainers, and organizations should pair AI-mediated negotiation exercises with structured debriefs that make implicit reward structures explicit and validate multiple effective communicative repertoires (e.g., agentic, communal, and integrative), rather than training users to optimize solely for what the chatbot rewards. At the same time, Glickman and Sharot (2025) show a silver lining: when AI outputs are accurate and reflect careful standards, human–AI feedback loops can train better human judgments. This suggests a constructive pathway forward: AI platforms can be useful learning tools if carefully calibrated and audited to minimize bias reproduction and reinforce reflective reasoning.

Organizations should therefore treat AI-mediated negotiation and evaluation systems as cultural artifacts that define effective speech and behavior. Auditing should extend beyond quantitative fairness metrics to include qualitative inquiry into whose voices and styles are rewarded. Instead of training individuals to adapt to algorithmic norms, diversity efforts should intervene at the level of system design and evaluation, fostering algorithmic pluralism in which AI values multiple ways of communicating and exercising agency and communality. Practically, this can include publishing the system's decision criteria, testing the agent on diverse linguistic styles, and incorporating plural evaluation criteria that reward relational competence and collaborative outcomes alongside value claiming.

Finally, the phenomenon we observed highlights the need for transparent intersectional AI algorithmic governance. Regulatory and industry standards should require multidimensional bias testing. For example, an AI negotiation platform could be certified not only for fairness in outcomes across gender or ethnicity but also for whether it amplifies specific gendered or cultural communication norms. Transparency around decision-making criteria is essential: If an AI system heavily weighs certain behaviors, this should be disclosed and subject to review. Feminist AI governance calls for the inclusion of diverse voices, including women, racial minorities, and worker representatives, in oversight and accountability processes (Kelan 2025; Wajcman and Young 2023).

5.4 | Limitations and Future Research

Although our study offers valuable insights and evidence, it also has several limitations that temper the generalizability of the conclusions.

First, despite a moderate sample size of 51 participants, significant differences emerged on key outcomes, suggesting that AI-mediated negotiations can meaningfully shape communication even within a relatively small student sample. At the same time, some analyses may have had limited statistical power to detect smaller effects, and a larger sample could reveal more subtle differences or clarify the marginal trends observed here. Relatedly, although all participants' data were included descriptively, the small non-binary sample limited inferential gender comparisons to women and men. Gendered dynamics in AI-mediated negotiations likely intersect with other social positions (e.g., class, race, ethnicity, and sexuality) (Crenshaw 1989). Because the present dataset did not include sufficient representation across these dimensions, we did not conduct intersectional subgroup analyses. This boundary condition should be considered when interpreting the findings and motivate future work examining how AI-mediated negotiation differentially benefits or disadvantages participants across intersecting structural constraints.

Second, the use of a college student sample offers insights into early-career negotiators who are increasingly interacting with AI systems. However, these participants may be more comfortable navigating institutional norms and adjusting tone and language than populations facing structural constraints, such as lower educational attainment or socio-economic status (Volkema 2004). For individuals in such contexts, negotiation may be perceived as higher stakes and more asymmetrical, where asserting needs could risk penalties (Kopelman and Olekalns 1999). These constraints may dampen experimentation with AI-suggested language strategies, particularly in time-pressured exchanges. In addition, our findings provide initial evidence from a U.S.-based English-language context; however, cultural norms and linguistic conventions vary across settings. The results may not generalize to contexts with different cultural expectations or to individuals for whom English is not their primary language. Future research could examine workplace samples and cross-cultural contexts to determine whether the AI effects observed here hold more broadly.

Third, the participants, mostly in their early twenties, largely reflect early-career rather than experienced professional negotiators. The simulation design allowed us to isolate communicative dynamics in a controlled environment, but it necessarily simplified real-world negotiation complexity. The stakes in the negotiation (points and extra credit) were lower than an actual job offer negotiation, and the interaction lacked non-verbal cues, long-term relational concerns, and organizational power asymmetries. As a result, it may have attenuated emotional arousal or relational complexity characteristic of real negotiations. We therefore caution against assuming the absence of gender differences extends to all contexts. For instance, negotiations involving highly emotional issues or AI systems with names, voices, or avatars that introduce additional cues may yield different outcomes.

Finally, we studied one configuration of an AI system at a particular point in time. The AI system used (ChatGPT-4.1-based chatbot) represents an early iteration of rapidly evolving negotiation agents. As AI models develop, their strategies and alignment procedures may change. For example, current models may exhibit agreeableness or people-pleasing (Sharma et al. 2023), potentially making concessions that a human manager or company might not. Future AIs might drive harder bargains or adapt more dynamically to users' patterns, introducing new forms of

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bias. Thus, findings in this configuration should be treated as provisional and subject to ongoing evaluation as AI negotiation tools become more sophisticated.

6 | Conclusion

This discussion situates our findings within broader debates on feminist technology and the future of work. A central contribution of this study is showing the nuanced reality that AI systems can simultaneously mitigate overt gender disparities while reproducing underlying gendered norms. This duality reflects a core tension in Feminist AI scholarship, which resists both celebratory and alarmist framings. Instead, it calls for engagement with the complex middle ground where AI can both disrupt and sustain existing power relations. Our findings underscore that AI will not become feminist or egalitarian by default; realizing such potential requires deliberate design choices that embed fairness, transparency, and respect for difference (Noble 2018; Wajcman 2006).

In closing, AI-mediated negotiation reveals both the potential and the peril of AI in organizational life. Although such systems hold promise for reducing explicit biases and fostering more meritocratic interactions, the danger lies in their invisible and implicit reinforcement of dominant cultural norms. A feminist technoscience perspective urges us neither to accept the status quo nor to disengage in resignation but to engage critically and constructively. The task ahead is to design AI systems that do not merely assimilate women and other marginalized individuals into the existing mold of the "ideal (male) worker" but instead help to reshape the mold itself. Achieving this transformation will require sustained collaboration among technologists, feminist theorists, workers, and policymakers. Integrating empirical evidence with technofeminist theory, this study suggests recursive human–AI gender learning as a mechanism through which AI's potential for progress is continually negotiated alongside the subtle reassertion of power.

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Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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Appendix A: Gendered-Language Pattern Coding Scheme

Feminine (F)

Definition: Language expressing communality, interpersonal sensitivity, emotional warmth, and relational support. Must include salient relational concern or emotional expression.

- F1: Emotion talk—clear emotional expressions like "feel," "worried," "excited"
- F2: Hedges—qualifiers like "maybe," "sort of," "I think"
- F3: Politeness/apologies—"sorry," "please," "thank you"
- F4: Compliments and empathy—praise or understanding of the other
- F5: Self-derogation—downplaying self-worth or certainty
- F6: Personal disclosure—sharing feelings or personal details
- F7: Cooperative appeals—language aimed at joint resolution
- F8: Subordinating conjunctions—"although," "because," linking for harmony
- F9: Social connection focus—referencing shared or others' needs
- F10: Supportive backchannels—affirming others, for example, "I see," "right"

Masculine (M)

Definition: Language emphasizing agency, assertiveness, task orientation, and control. Must include dominant tone or action-seeking framing.

- M1: Assertive/directive language—unhedged commands or firm statements

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- M2: Opinions and evaluations—firm judgments or assessments
- M3: Task-focus—focus on goals, metrics, or outcomes
- M4: Interruption or turn control—dominating turn-taking or framing
- M5: Minimal emotional content—avoids affect, prefers logic
- M6: Strategic anchoring—aggressive first offers or stakes
- M7: Self-promotion—emphasizes own skill/value
- M8: Competitive framing—zero-sum framing of gains/losses
- M9: Certainty terms—"definitely," "must," and "obviously"
- M10: Objectivity appeals—logical or analytical framing

Androgynous (A)

Definition: Language that integrates salient and balanced expressions of both agency and communality within a turn or intent.

- A1: Strategic empathy—balancing assertiveness and understanding
- A2: Balanced proposals—goal-oriented but empathetic suggestions
- A3: Assertive politeness—directive paired with relational language
- A4: Emotional intelligence—anticipating tone or reactions strategically
- A5: Mixed framing—toggling facts and feelings meaningfully
- A6: Flexibility—style-shifting in real time for harmony or effectiveness
- A7: Joint ownership language—"we," "us," tied to shared action
- A8: Clear reasoning and acknowledgment—synthesis of logic and empathy
- A9: Balanced use of certainty and hedges
- A10: Uses both feminine and masculine coded traits with equal salience

Undifferentiated (U)

Definition: Language low in both agency and communality. Often vague, disengaged, emotionally flat, or lacking strategy.

- U1: Minimal engagement—short or non-substantive replies
- U2: Disorganized or confused—no clear structure or goal
- U3: Passive voice/indifference—"I guess ..." "whatever"
- U4: Repetition or avoidance—loops or dodging negotiation
- U5: Emotionally flat—emotionally neutral when context expects affect
- U6: Lack of focus—irrelevant or diffuse topics
- U7: Low self-disclosure or initiative—no new ideas offered
- U8: Missing indicators—lacks clear traits of F or M
- U9: Ambivalent language—indecision without justification
- U10: Appears disengaged from interaction goals

Sources: Bem (1974), Guiller and Durndell (2007), Hussey et al. (2015), and Kray and Thompson (2004): Gendered language patterns that categorizes expressions into four dimensions: masculine, feminine, androgynous, and undifferentiated.

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